ACMC 2014: Live Diffusion Concert – Thursday July 10 at 8PM
VCA Founders Gallery

Surround sound system supplied by Mark Pedersen @ Chailight Productions: www.chailight.com

Paulina Sundin, Monty Adkins, Jonny Axelsson - Splintered Echoes

This work is the result of an extended period of research investigating how the work of William Sethares can be implemented in electroacoustic composition. Software has been constructed in Max/MSP by Adrian Gierakowski directed by Paulina Sundin that enables an spectrum analysis of sound files to be created. Scales of the most significant partials are then extracted. The software enables scales to be transposed onto any existing scale step as well as morphed on to a different scale from a different analysis. A series of live tools have then been constructed to enable the performance and live electronic manipulation of these elements.

The composition of the work took the form of a series of improvisations held at EMS Stockholm in February 2014. As a result the harmonic and large-scale formal progression of the piece is fixed. There are five movements based around the spectrum of i) a drum ii) a low bell iii) temple block iv) a gong and v) a combination of gong and drum spectrums. The moment to moment progression of the piece is improvised. The overall shape of specific movements has been discussed in advance, however, there is no score for the percussion. Axelsson both leads the electronics through his gestures and is able to respond to what results from the transformations presented by Sundin and Adkins.

Splintered Echoes was first performed live at the Beyond Pythagoras Symposium held at the University of Huddersfield in March 2014. At the ACMC the piece will be performed by Jonny Axelsson playing against a fixed media part prepared by Adkins and Sundin.

Yu Tao - Peach Blossom Fan

Peach Blossom Fan is a legendary play written by Kong Shangren of the early Qing Dynasty in 1699. In total, the play has 40 chapters divided into three sections. The story goes that during the period of the late Ming Dynasty, members of the Donglin Party fled for their lives to Nanjing and re- established "Fushe" (the Restoration Society), fighting against the deposed official Ruan Dacheng. Dacheng remained a confederate of Wei Zhongxian, a eunuch who seized all the powers of the state. Hou Fangyu, one of the mainstays of the Restoration Society, met a geisha named Li Xiangjun, and the two fell in love. Hou Fangyu sent a fan inscribed with a poem to Li Xiangjun and married her. Ruan Dacheng asked someone to send a substantial dowry to ingratiate himself with Hou Fangyu, but the dowry was handed back by Li Xiangjun after she learnt the identity of the sender. For this reason, Ruan Dacheng harboured resentment in his heart. After Emperor Hongguang took the throne, Ruan Dacheng was reappointed to an important position. He took the opportunity to falsely incriminate Hou Fangyu, forcing him to seek shelter from Shi Kefa, and coercing Li Xiangjun to marry someone else. Li did not yield to him and hit her head against the wall to commit suicide. She failed, and the blood spattered on the fan. Yang Longyou, a friend of Hou Fangyu, used the blood drops to draw a branch of peach blossoms with them. When the Ming Dynasty collapsed, Li Xiangjun went to live in the mountains and became a nun. And when Yangzhou fell, Hou Fangyu fled to Nanjing to look for Li Xiangjun. He finally converted to Taoism, following Li Xiangjun's path. The Peach Blossom Fan is said to be "a painting of social scenes in late dynasty" periods, in which the contents are complicated, the roles various, and the scenes motley.
The music here describes one of these scenes. A transformation of the flute brings a new quality to the sound, which seems like a human scream; it enters into dialogue with the voice of the flutist. Moreover, an installation of a lighting system in the tube of the flute adds a subtle light variation which follows the fingering changes. The electroacoustic part is written for six channels that contrast with the flute on the stage.

Text :

萧然 美人去远

Xiao ran, mei ren qu yuan
Desolate I wander, distant my only beloved.

重门锁 云山万千 知情只有闲莺燕

Chong men suo, yun shan wan qian, zhi qing zhi you xian ying yan
Daunting the walls between us, these thousand, ten thousand, mountains. Only the faithful oriole knows my heart.

尽着狂 尽着颠

Jin zhuo kuang, jin zhuo dian
All is madness All is folly

问着他一双双不会传言

Wen zhe ta yi shuang shuang bu hui chuan yan
Cannot the oriole bring news of my love?

熬煎

Ao jian!
Sorrow!

想当日猛然舍抛

Xiang dang ri meng ran she pao
How cruel the day of our parting!

银河渺渺谁架桥

Yin he miao miao shei jia qiao
In old stories, the magpies formed bridges to let lovers meet for their trysts,

墙高更比天际高 书难捎

Qiang gao geng bi tian ji gao, shu nan shao
but the walls which divided us were higher than the sky, far too high to be crossed by letters.

梦空劳 情无了 出来路儿越迢遥

Meng kong lao, qing wu liao, chu lai lu er yue tiao yao
Our dreams were vain, and love was quickly fleeting. Oh, the winding ways we travelled!

曾见金陵玉殿莺啼晓 秦淮水榭花开早

Ceng jian jin ling yu dian ying ti xiao, qin huai shui xie hua kai zao
At dawn, I have heard the oriole sing by the great houses of Nanjing. I have seen the flowers blossom by the riverside.

谁知容易冰消

Shei zhi rong yi bing xiao
Who was to know that it might so easily vanish?

眼看他起朱楼 眼看他宴宾客 眼看他楼塌了

Yan kan ta qi zhu lou, yan kan ta yan bin ke, yan kan ta lou ta liao
I saw them build the courtesan's quarters, saw them feast and make merry. But I saw, too, how the building collapsed.

这青苔碧瓦堆

Zhe qing tai bi wa dui
Now moss covers those piles of broken bricks.

那乌衣巷不姓王 莫愁湖鬼夜哭 凤凰台栖枭鸟

Na wu yi xiang bu xing wang, mo chou hu gui ye ku, feng hung tai qi xiao niao
The old families no longer live in those houses; and the ghosts' nocturnal wailing echoes on the lake. The houses of power have become owl roosts.

残山梦最真 旧境丢掉难 不信这舆图换稿

Can shan meng zui zhen, jiu jing dui nan diao, bu xin zhe yu tu huan gao
Broken dreams are the most real, and sights once seen are hard to forget.

诌一套哀江南 放悲声唱到老

Zhou yi tao ai jiang nan, fang bei sheng chang dao lao
I have written these laments for you. Intone them sadly, and grow old.

Lindsay Ross Vickery - Sacrificial Zones

For clarinet and electronics.
In his "Days of Destruction, Days of Revolt" Chris Hedges details a number of places in the US which he describes as "sacrificial zones", places that have essentially been abandoned by society and government. One of the places he visits is Camden New Jersey. It was once a hub of industry, but has become a no-go zone with large homeless camps, ruled by gangs, with a permanent underclass of unemployed. The graphical score (Figure 1.) for Sacrificial Zones is a collage created from images of Camden.

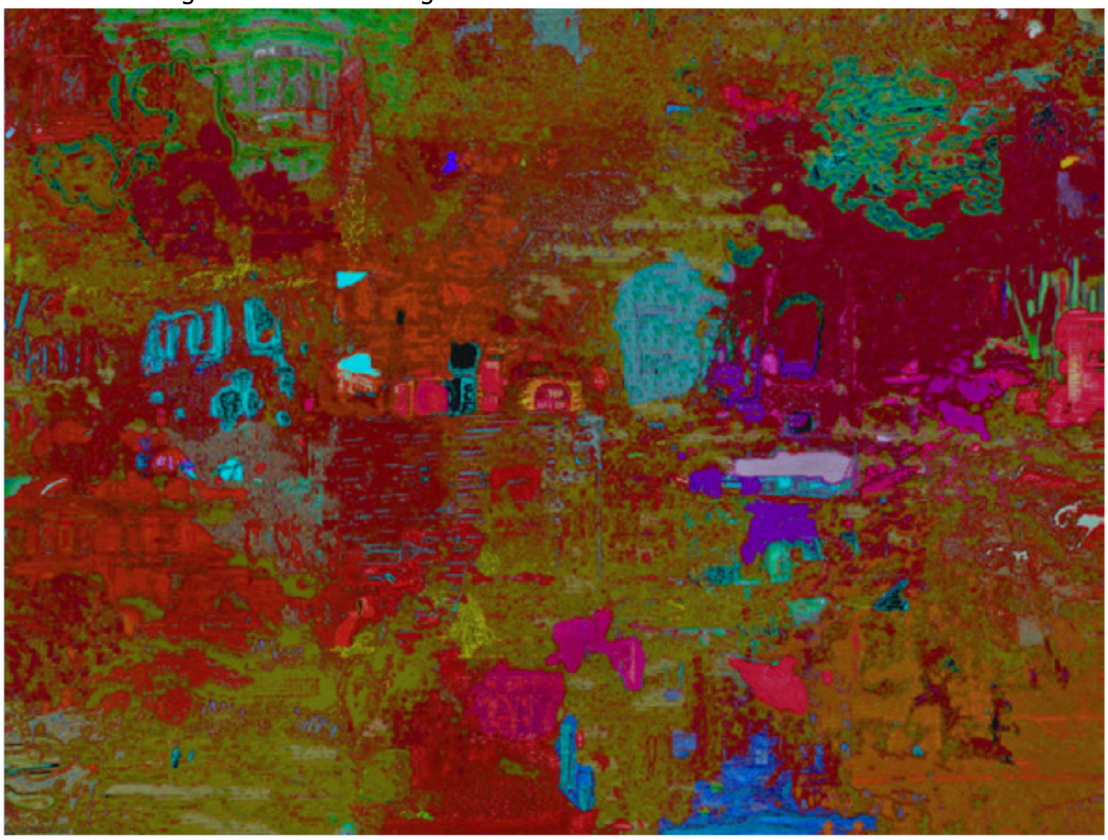


Figure 1. The graphical score for Sacrificial Zones

Sacrificial Zones is a rhizomatic score in which the performer reads along intersecting pathways that are orientated both vertically and horizontally (Figure 2.).

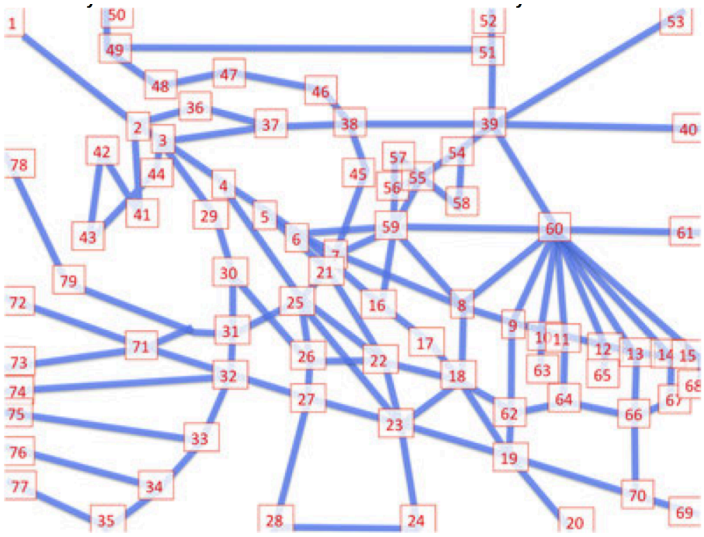


Figure 2. Rhizomatic pathways in Sacrificial Zones

In addition, the score is comprised of five layers each notated in a different manner: non-semantic, semantic, traditional, proportional and spectrogram (Figure 3.). The notated score was evolved from improvisations based on "readings' of the non- semantic notation.

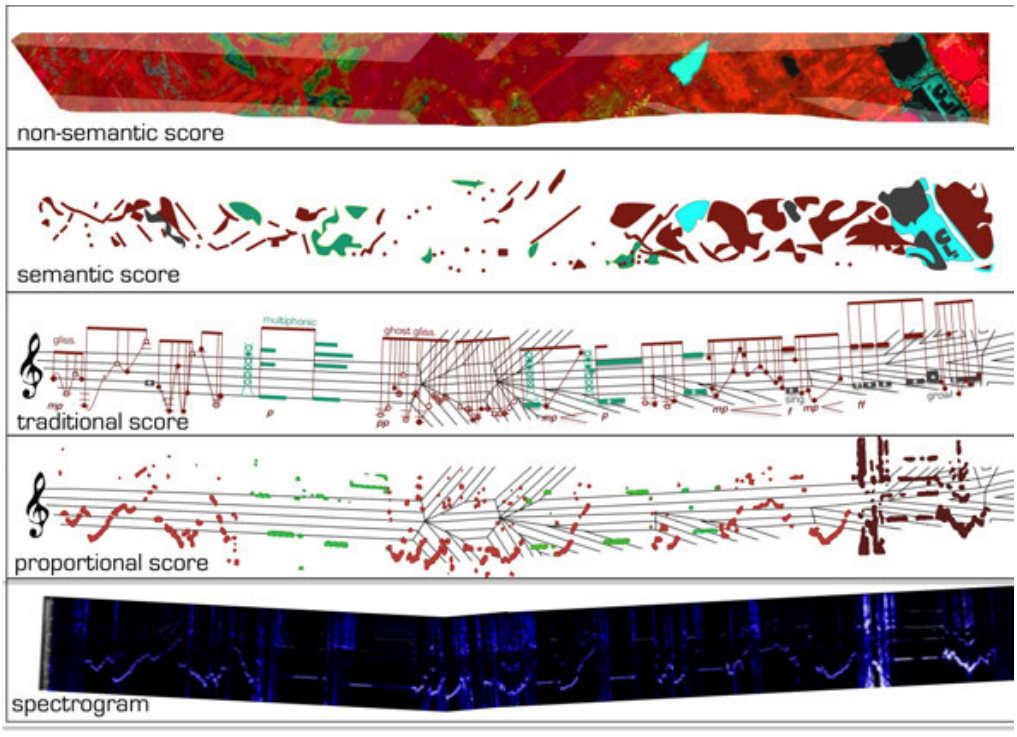


Figure 3. Five forms of notation used in Sacrificial Zones

The material to be realized by the performer is specified by a moving circle on the score. The work unfolds indeterminately along its rhizomatic pathways, and also cross-fades between the five notational paradigms. The clarinet performance is processed by delay, pitch shift, distortion, spectral manipulation and ring modulation.

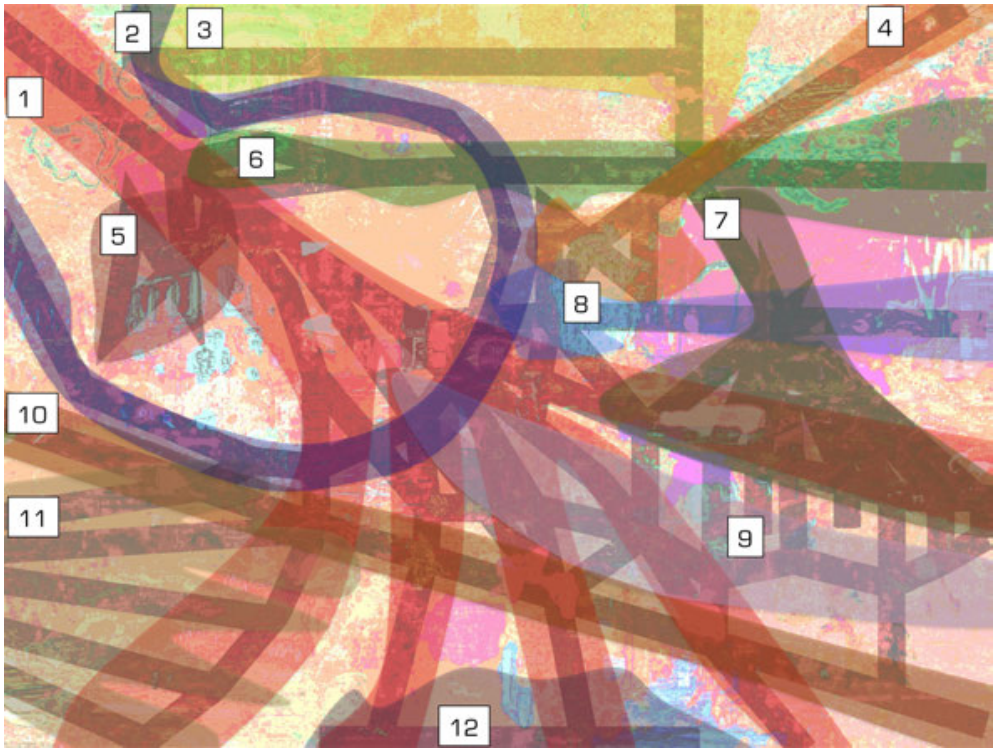


Figure 4. Signal Processing zones in Sacrificial Zones

The amplified sound of the live clarinettist is diffused to four (or eight) speakers in a spatial location analogous to the position of the performer on the score. The electronically processed signal follows a separate path through the space. One instantiation of the pathways is shown in Figure 5.

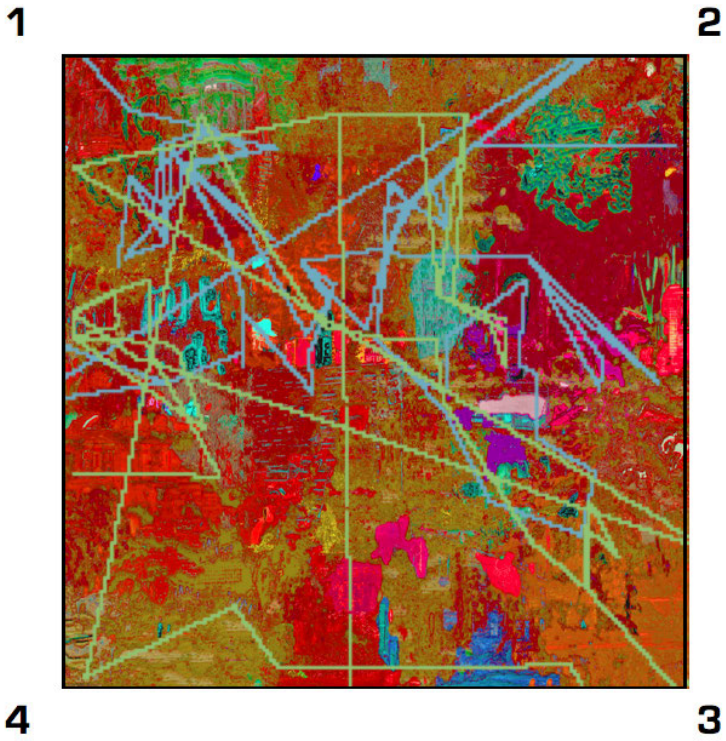


Figure 5. One instantiation of spatialisation pathways Sacrificial Zones

Steve Adam - An Abbreviated Space (for Lawrence Whiffin)

For solo flute, computer and spatial sound system.

Flute: Tamara Kohler, computer: Steve 'Stelios' Adam

Commissioned by the Astra Chamber Music Society earlier this year as part of a memorial concert for Lawrence (Laurie) Whiffin, teacher, colleague and friend, *An Abbreviated Space* draws on Whiffin's short serial work *A Brief Moment* - for woodwind trio - as a point of departure.The title and organising principles of the piece assume something of a spatial analogue to the temporal theme of Laurie's title, where initial ideas about spectral treatments and layering of a selection of motifs gradually evolved to embrace spatiality - not simply in terms of the effect of sounds moving across a sound field (though they do), but as a means of shaping formal aspects of the work. To this end, a larger collection of discrete sound elements – all derived in one way or another from the performer – roam through a virtual space, only becoming apparent to the listener as they traverse the 'window of audition'. With thanks to Tamara Kohler for performing the piece tonight with relatively short notice and to Mardi McSullea for her contribution to the development and first performance of the work.

Bio: Steve Stelios Adam has harboured a long-term fascination with music, sound and its associated technologies. As a composer and sound artist, Steve has created works for a variety of media and performed with instrumentalists, ensembles, choirs and interactive music systems of his own design. His electro-acoustic works have been presented both nationally and abroad and appear in recordings by Move Records, ANU and ABC Classics. Informed by the technical challenges of his own works, he occasionally consults for other artists and organisations to develop software designs for specialised media-based projects.